The Complete Cost of Living & Relocation Guide

AMSTERDAM, NETHERLANDS

2 0 2 6 E D I T I O N

Data-Driven Insights for Remote Workers, Expats & Global Professionals

Prepared by **Living Cost Atlas Analytics Division** | Relocation Intelligence Report | 2026

Table of Contents

	Section	Page
01	Executive Summary	3
02	Quick Fact Sheet	5
03	Detailed Cost Breakdown	7
04	Monthly Budget Scenarios	10
05	Neighborhood Analysis	12
06	Work Infrastructure	14
07	Safety & Quality of Life	15
08	City Comparison	16
09	Pros & Cons Summary	18
10	Who Should Move?	19
11	Risk Factors	20
12	LCA Index Methodology	21
13	Final Verdict	22
A	Appendix A -- First 30 Days	24
B	Appendix B -- Scams & Gotchas	26
C	Appendix C -- Visa Deep-Dive	27

01. Executive Summary

Amsterdam in 2026 is the most English-friendly city in continental Europe and one of the most housing-constrained. Dutch English proficiency is effectively native-equivalent in professional settings, infrastructure is world-class, and the Dutch-American Friendship Treaty (DAFT) visa remains one of the cheapest founder-entry routes into the Schengen Area at roughly EUR 4,500 in business capital.

The defining issue, as it has been since 2015, is housing. Rent-regulated (social) housing is effectively inaccessible to newcomers; the private market is tight, expensive, and increasingly hostile to short-term corporate leases. Energy costs remain elevated post-2022, and a broader Dutch political shift toward reducing expat tax breaks (the 30% ruling is being tapered) has softened Amsterdam's net package for new arrivals.

Verdict for 2026: BUY for remote workers earning in USD/GBP and willing to accept housing friction; CONDITIONAL for dual-resident couples, families needing multi-bedroom stock, and anyone expecting the historical 30% ruling in its original form.

Estimated Monthly Living Costs -- 2026

Resident Profile	Monthly Estimate (EUR)	Lifestyle Descriptor
Budget Nomad	€3 850 -- €5 005	Shared housing, local transport, home cooking
Standard Remote Professional	€6 600 -- €8 580	Private 1BR, coworking, regular dining out
Premium Lifestyle Expat	€13 800 -- €20 700+	Prime district, premium services

Key Strengths

Strength	Commentary
Remote-Friendly Visa	DAFT / Self-Employment Visa available for remote workers. Minimum income requirement: €1 500/month.
Digital Infrastructure	Average WiFi speeds of 200 Mbps. Coworking from €350/month.
Safety Profile	Safety index: 80/100. Crime level: Low.
Healthcare	Healthcare quality score: 92/100.
English Proficiency	English proficiency: 95/100 -- excellent for international residents.

Key Risks

Risk Factor	Impact Summary
Cost Trajectory	Inflation rate: 2.9%. Rent volatility index: 8/10. Housing costs are rising significantly.
Tax Burden	Top personal income tax rate: 49.5%. Corporate tax: 25.8%. Capital gains: 31%.
Currency Risk	Currency stability: High. Minimal FX risk.

Living Cost Atlas Index Score -- Amsterdam 2026

Dimension	Weight	Score	Contribution
Affordability	30%	4.9 / 10	1.47
Infrastructure	20%	9.4 / 10	1.89
Safety	15%	8.0 / 10	1.20
Quality of Life	20%	8.9 / 10	1.78
Economic Stability	15%	7.5 / 10	1.13

Dimension	Weight	Score	Contribution
COMPOSITE	**100%**	**--**	**7.46 / 10**

7.46/10 (BUY) -- Amsterdam represents solid value for international residents.

02. Quick Fact Sheet

Parameter	Value / Estimate	Context
Country	Netherlands	Europe
Currency	EUR (€)	Stability: High
Rent -- 1BR City Centre	€5 100 / month	Varies by district
Rent -- 1BR Outside Centre	€3 300 / month	Commuter accessible
Coworking (Hot Desk)	€350 / month	Available citywide
Internet Speed (avg.)	200 Mbps	
Safety Index	80 / 100	Crime: Low
Visa	DAFT / Self-Employment Visa	Remote-worker friendly
Visa Processing	90 days	Stay: 24 months
Min. Income Req.	€1 500/month	For visa qualification
Top Income Tax	49.5%	Personal income
Corporate Tax	25.8%	
Inflation Rate	2.9%	Annual
Public Transport	95 / 100	
Healthcare Quality	92 / 100	
English Proficiency	95 / 100	
Airport Connectivity	95 / 100	
Nomad Score	85 / 100	LCA composite

03. Detailed Cost Breakdown

Itemized monthly cost estimates across major expenditure categories for international residents in Amsterdam. All figures in EUR and reflect Q1 2026 estimates.

Housing

Accommodation Type	Monthly Cost (€)	Notes
Studio / 1BR -- City Centre	€5 100	Average; varies by district
Studio / 1BR -- Outside Centre	€3 300	Commuter areas
2BR -- City Centre	€7 650	Estimated from 1BR rate
2BR -- Outside Centre	€4 950	Family-suitable
Shared Room / Coliving	€1 650	Budget option
Short-term (Airbnb-style)	€9 180	Monthly rate; higher daily

Food & Dining

Category	Daily Cost (€)	Monthly Estimate
Budget (cooking at home)	€15	€450
Standard (mix of cooking & dining)	€35	€1 050
Premium (frequent dining out)	€90	€2 700

Amsterdam's food scene has improved dramatically over the last decade but remains expensive per-meal compared to Southern Europe: a mid-tier dinner-for-two easily runs EUR 80-120. Groceries at Albert Heijn, Jumbo, and Turkish/Moroccan corner shops (for fresh produce) are reasonable, and home cooking is the actual cost-controlling lever here. Dutch food culture remains pragmatic (broodjes, fries, herring); the genuine depth lives in Indonesian, Surinamese, and Middle-Eastern diaspora cuisines.

Transport & Connectivity

Item	Monthly Cost (€)
Public Transport Pass	€100
Coworking (Hot Desk)	€350
Internet (Home)	€40
Mobile Plan	€25

04. Monthly Budget Scenarios

Three archetypal resident profiles for Amsterdam 2026.

Profile 1 -- Budget Nomad

Expense	Amount (€)
Accommodation (shared/suburb)	€3 300
Food (home cooking)	€450
Transport	€100
Internet + Mobile	€50
Entertainment	€80
TOTAL	**€3 850 -- €5 005**

Profile 2 -- Standard Remote Professional

Expense	Amount (€)
Accommodation (1BR centre)	€5 100
Food (mixed)	€1 050
Transport	€100
Coworking	€350
Internet + Mobile	€50
Entertainment + Dining	€200
TOTAL	**€6 600 -- €8 580**

Profile 3 -- Premium Lifestyle Expat

Expense	Amount (€)
Accommodation (premium 2BR)	€10 200
Food (premium)	€2 700
Transport (car + public)	€200
Coworking (dedicated)	€700
Healthcare + Insurance	€765
Entertainment + Travel	€400
TOTAL	**€13 800 -- €20 700+**

05. Neighborhood Analysis

Five neighborhood profiles for Amsterdam evaluating rental economics, lifestyle character, and demographic fit.

Jordaan

District Type: Historic + Premium | Est. 1BR Rent: €6 197 -- €7 918/month

Canal-ring postcard Amsterdam with narrow 17th-century houses, galleries, and the highest per-sqm rents in the city.

Best For -- High-income professionals who want to live inside the UNESCO ring.

De Pijp

District Type: Trendy + Dense | Est. 1BR Rent: €5 279 -- €6 745/month

Dense, lively, and food-forward around Albert Cuyp market; effectively Amsterdam's answer to Brooklyn.

Best For -- Single remote workers and couples in their late 20s-30s.

Oud-Zuid

District Type: Family + Upmarket | Est. 1BR Rent: €5 967 -- €7 624/month

South of Vondelpark with museums, leafy streets, and the densest concentration of international schools.

Best For -- Relocating families and long-term expats with children.

Oost (East)

District Type: Rising + Mixed | Est. 1BR Rent: €4 361 -- €5 572/month

Post-gentrification wave east of the centre with parks, the Tropenmuseum, and better value per sqm than ring-adjacent zones.

Best For -- Value-conscious professionals who still want 15-minute bike access to the centre.

Noord (North)

District Type: Newest + Creative | Est. 1BR Rent: €3 672 -- €4 692/month

Across the IJ from Centraal, post-industrial conversion projects, the EYE museum, and the best remaining rent value in the city.

Best For -- Creatives and newer arrivals willing to take the 5-minute free ferry daily.

06. Work Infrastructure & Digital Readiness

Dimension	Score	Assessment
Internet Speed	200 Mbps	Excellent -- fiber widely available
Coworking Ecosystem	€350/mo	Mid-to-premium pricing
Public Transport	95/100	World-class transit system
English Proficiency	95/100	Excellent -- business-ready
Airport Connectivity	95/100	Major international hub

Commentary. Amsterdam's digital infrastructure positions it well for remote workers. Strong English proficiency reduces friction for international professionals.

07. Safety & Quality of Life

Dimension	Score	Notes
Safety Index	80/100	Crime level: Low
Healthcare Quality	92/100	Public + private options
Public Transport	95/100	Daily commute viability
English Proficiency	95/100	Ease of integration
Airport Access	95/100	Travel connectivity
Nomad Score	85/100	Overall remote-worker suitability

Seven-Dimension Lived Quality Scorecard

Dimension	Score	Notes
Climate	5.5/10	Temperate-oceanic: mild summers (18-24C), damp autumns, dark winters (Dec daylight under 8h). Spring (Apr-May) is the sweet spot.
Walkability	9.5/10	Canal-ring geography is one of the most walkable/cyclable in the world. Tram + bike covers 95% of needs; car is a liability in central districts.
Healthcare	8.5/10	Mandatory private-insured public system is genuinely excellent. GP-gated access can frustrate newcomers used to direct-specialist models.
Safety (Lived)	8.5/10	Low violent-crime rates; bike theft and occasional tourist-zone pickpocketing are the main vectors. Women-solo safety is excellent by European standards.
Culture & Arts	9/10	Rijksmuseum, Van Gogh, Stedelijk, Concertgebouw, and a live-music scene that punches far above city size. Genuine cultural depth.
Air Quality	7.5/10	Generally good; occasional NOx issues along major corridors. No PM2.5 problems typical of warmer-climate peers.
Green Space	8/10	Vondelpark, Westerpark, Oosterpark, Amsterdamse Bos (urban forest). Per-capita green space is high for a dense European capital.

Commentary. Amsterdam scores 80/100 on safety, placing it in the safe-to-moderate range. Healthcare at 92/100 meets international standards.

08. City Comparison -- Amsterdam vs. Peer Cities

Amsterdam benchmarked against regionally appropriate peers. Rent differentials are expressed as percentage relative to Amsterdam.

- **Berlin** -- The other English-friendly Northern European creative hub; cheaper, grittier.
- **London** -- Larger English-speaking financial peer; more expensive across the board.
- **Stockholm** -- Nordic peer on quality-of-life metrics with harsher winters.
- **Paris** -- Closest cultural-capital peer at a similar price point.

City	1BR Rent	vs. Amsterdam	Safety	Nomad Score
Amsterdam (baseline)	€5 100	--	80/100	85/100
Berlin	€3 300	-35%	80/100	82/100
London	£5 700	+12%	75/100	74/100
Stockholm	kr4 650	-9%	92/100	87/100
Paris	€4 800	-6%	70/100	80/100

Commentary. Among peer cities, Amsterdam sits at a moderate price point. Berlin provides the closest comparison in lifestyle and cost profile.

09. Pros & Cons Summary

Strengths

Strength	Detail
Near-Native English	Highest English proficiency in continental Europe; Dutch is optional for most professional roles.
Cycling Infrastructure	World-class bike network makes a car actively unnecessary in most of the city.
DAFT Visa	EUR 4,500 capital requirement is the cheapest legitimate Schengen founder route.
Schiphol Connectivity	One of Europe's top-3 airports; 300+ direct destinations.
Strong Public Healthcare	Mandatory insurance (~EUR 150/month) gives access to excellent public system.
Walkable + Human-Scale	Canal-ring geography rewards walking and cycling over transit; compact, safe, and culturally dense.
Tech + Startup Ecosystem	Booking.com, Adyen, Philips, Picnic and a dense startup cluster make Amsterdam a real tech hub.
International Schools Depth	AICS (public international), British School of Amsterdam, International School of Amsterdam -- multiple strong options.

Limitations

Limitation	Detail
Housing Market Dysfunction	Supply-constrained, regulated, and hostile to short-term corporate rentals; first 3-6 months are often the hardest.
30% Ruling Tapering	Historical expat tax break is being progressively reduced; factor the new rules, not old ones.
Dark Winters	Nov-Feb daylight and cloud cover are a real wellbeing factor.
High Per-Meal Dining Cost	Restaurants are a premium spend compared to Southern European peers.
High Tax Bracket	Top marginal PIT of 49.5% applies quickly; effective tax hit is real even with ruling applied.
Damp / Older Housing	Pre-war canal stock has damp, heating, and noise issues; post-2000 builds in Oost/Zuidas are the comfort-first option.
Banking Bureaucracy	Dutch banks (ABN, ING, Rabo) can be slow to open accounts for non-EU residents without BSN; DAFT applicants face extra friction.
Social Depth vs Breadth	Large expat community but genuine Dutch integration is a multi-year project; the first year feels transactional for many.

10. Who Should Move to Amsterdam?

Amsterdam works on Dutch directness: social calendars are planned weeks ahead, work-life boundaries are hard, and unsolicited feedback is the default communication mode. Cycling is not a lifestyle choice -- it's the transport baseline, and a city that doesn't bike has a materially worse time. The expat community is enormous but compartmentalised; integration with Dutch peers is a medium-term project, not a first-month one.

Solo Remote Workers

RECOMMENDED

Near-native English environment, EUR 100+ Mbps fibre, excellent coworking (TQ, B.Amsterdam, Spaces). The DAFT route suits US founders; employer sponsorship handles the rest.

Digital Nomads (3-6 months)

CONDITIONAL

No dedicated nomad visa, Schengen 90/180 limits apply, and short-let housing is regulated (60-day rental cap per year for most units). Suits project-length stays more than nomad circuits.

Relocating Families

RECOMMENDED

Excellent bilingual/international schools (AICS, ISA, BSA), bike-safe streets, and strong public healthcare. Main friction is 3BR+ housing stock in Oud-Zuid or Oost.

Retirees

CONDITIONAL

No dedicated retirement visa; EU citizens have easy access, non-EU retirees face the standard residency/income pathway. Dark winters are the single biggest factor to stress-test.

Entrepreneurs

RECOMMENDED

DAFT visa is the lowest-capital Schengen founder entry for US citizens. Dutch BV structures, startup-friendly legal environment, and Schiphol logistics are genuine advantages.

11. Risk Factors & Economic Outlook

Risk Vector	Level	Assessment
Housing Scarcity	HIGH	Finding a private long-term rental typically takes 4-12 weeks with real competition; many newcomers spend 3-6 months in serviced or short-let before securing stable housing.
30% Ruling Taper	MODERATE	The expat tax ruling is being reduced (30%/20%/10% over 5 years structure). Tax-net-of-ruling calculations based on old assumptions no longer hold.
Climate (Damp + Dark)	MODERATE	Nov-Feb daylight averages under 8 hours with high cloud cover. SAD is a documented issue; light therapy and winter exits are common.
Bike Theft + Damp Housing	LOW	Bike theft is near-universal at the 1-2-year mark; older canal-house stock has damp/heating issues that surprise newcomers from drier climates.
Energy Costs	MODERATE	Post-2022 energy price shock has softened but EUR 150-350/month for gas+electric is typical for 70-100m2 stock; heat-pump conversion is accelerating but uneven.
Overtourism Backlash	LOW	City has restricted short-lets, capped cruise ship visits, and is tightening rules on tourist-visible business. Long-term residents are largely insulated but policy direction is restrictive.

12. Living Cost Atlas Index Methodology

The LCA Index is a composite scoring framework providing standardized relocation intelligence across global cities.

Dimension	Weight	Data Sources
Affordability	30%	Rent indices, grocery costs, transport, coworking pricing
Infrastructure	20%	Internet speed, public transport, healthcare, airport connectivity
Safety	15%	Crime indices, political stability, emergency services
Quality of Life	20%	Climate, walkability, culture, healthcare access
Economic Stability	15%	Currency stability, inflation, GDP growth, policy environment

LCA Index = (Affordability x 0.30) + (Infrastructure x 0.20) + (Safety x 0.15) + (Quality of Life x 0.20) + (Economic Stability x 0.15)

Score Range	Classification	Guidance
8.0 -- 10.0	STRONG BUY	Top-tier destination; plan actively
6.5 -- 7.99	BUY	Solid destination; proceed with planning
5.0 -- 6.49	HOLD	Selective appeal; detailed research required
Below 5.0	CAUTION	Significant trade-offs; specialist advice recommended

13. Final Verdict

Living Cost Atlas's assessment of Amsterdam as a 2026 relocation destination.

LCA Index	Classification	Recommendation
7.46 out of 10.0	BUY	PROCEED WITH PLANNING

Amsterdam scores 7.46/10 on the Living Cost Atlas Index, classified as BUY. Amsterdam offers solid fundamentals for international residents.

Verdict for Digital Nomads

Amsterdam is not a digital-nomad city in the low-cost sense -- no DNV, 90/180 Schengen limits, and short-let housing rules make rotation difficult. For self-employed US citizens, the DAFT visa (EUR 4,500 capital requirement) is the cheapest legitimate Schengen founder entry and unlocks legal long-stay. For employed remote workers on sponsored visas, the tax-after-ruling math must be re-run under the 30/20/10 tapered regime that now applies.

Verdict for Families

Families do well here once housing is secured: bike-safe streets, excellent international schools (AICS, ISA, BSA), strong public healthcare, and a genuinely child-friendly cultural norm. The single biggest friction is 3BR+ housing stock; Oud-Zuid and Oost have the best inventory but prices run EUR 3,500-5,500/month for family-size apartments, and waitlists at top schools start 12-18 months ahead.

Verdict for Founders & Entrepreneurs

For founders with US citizenship, DAFT is a genuine asset: Schengen residency, Dutch BV structure, and a mature startup ecosystem (TQ, Rockstart, Startupbootcamp). For EU founders, the standard freelance or BV path is straightforward but tax rates are high. Amsterdam rewards B2B SaaS and deep-tech over cost-sensitive consumer plays; the cost base is real but the quality of the ecosystem is worth it for the right business.

CLOSING STATEMENT

Amsterdam in 2026 is the best-infrastructured, most English-friendly city in continental Europe -- and its most housing-constrained. BUY for remote workers and founders who can navigate housing and tax; CONDITIONAL BUY for families (school waitlists + housing stock); CAUTION for budget nomads -- this is not a cost-optimisation city.

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A. Appendix: Getting Set Up -- Your First 30 Days

A practical field handbook for the first month in Amsterdam. Banking, mobile, coworking, essential apps, and a week-by-week bureaucracy timeline -- the real operational sequence that determines whether your relocation stalls or stabilises.

Banking

Provider	Notes
ING Netherlands	Most foreigner-friendly. Needs BSN (citizen service number) and proof-of-address. Current account free; iDEAL integration is essential for Dutch online payments.

Provider	Notes
ABN AMRO	Premium alternative with stronger English service and private-banking tiers; EUR 2.95/mo for basic account.
bunq (digital)	Green bank licensed in NL; opens in 5 minutes with passport, no BSN required initially. Useful bridge while waiting for BSN appointment (2-6 week queue in 2026).

Mobile / SIM

Operator	Plan & Price
KPN	Best national coverage + home fibre. SIM-only EUR 20-30/mo 20GB + EU roaming.
Odido (T-Mobile NL)	Best 5G in Amsterdam core. Postpaid Max plan EUR 25/mo 30GB.
Lebara / Simyo	Cheap prepaid MVNOs on KPN/Odido. EUR 10/mo 5GB for bridge month.

Coworking -- Named Recommendations

Space	Area	Price & Vibe
B. Amsterdam	Sloterdijk	EUR 350/mo hot desk. Huge complex, 3 buildings, strong startup ecosystem, shuttle to centre.
TSH Collab	multiple sites	EUR 250-400/mo. Attached to The Student Hotel (now TSH); cafe + gym + pool included at some locations.
WeWork Weteringschans	Centrum	EUR 450-600/mo. Premium central location, strong for client meetings.

Essential Apps

- 9292 (multi-modal transit)
- NS (train)
- GVB (Amsterdam metro/tram)
- Thuisbezorgd (food delivery)
- Uber Eats / Deliveroo
- Tikkie (P2P payments)
- DigiD (government digital ID)

Week-by-Week Timeline

W1 Week 1 -- Arrive on Dutch residence permit (DAFT for Americans, HSM, Orientation Year, or EU free movement). Airbnb or TSH short-stay. Odido/KPN SIM.

W2 Week 2 -- Register at municipality (gemeente) for BSN -- book appointment online, bring birth certificate apostilled + translated, signed lease or landlord statement.

W3 Week 3 -- BSN arrives by post in 5-10 days. Open ING account same week. Apply for DigiD (government login -- required for health insurance, tax, utilities).

W4 Week 4 -- Dutch basic health insurance (legally required within 4 months): Zilveren Kruis, CZ, or VGZ -- EUR 140-170/mo. Home fibre (KPN/Ziggo). Transit pass (OV-chipkaart).

B. Appendix: Common Scams & Gotchas

The defensive manual. These are the recurring scams, rent-hustles, and bureaucratic traps that cost new arrivals real money in Amsterdam. Each entry is a known-pattern with the counter-move in one line.

Scam / Gotcha	How to defuse
Bike-rental "damage" scams	Operator claims pre-existing damage at return. Use MacBike or Yellow Bike with itemised rental contracts; photograph the bike at pickup.
Fake "universal" metro ticket touts	Street sellers offer "valid all-network" passes near Centraal. Only buy GVB/OV-chipkaart at machines or in app.
Red Light District pickpockets	Professional crews operate around Warmoesstraat + Damrak. Front pockets only; no wallets in back.
Rogue mortgage / BSN scam ads	Facebook offers to "fast-track BSN registration" for EUR 500-1000. Only the gemeente issues a BSN; never pay a third party.
Deposit-return sabotage in private sublets	Airbnb-style sublets sometimes withhold 1-month deposit citing fabricated damage. Use licensed agencies (Pararius, Funda); photograph inventory at check-in.
Cafe "coffeeshop" drug-dealer hustlers	Unlicensed dealers near Leidseplein sell cut/adulterated product. Only licensed coffeeshops with the green-and-white symbol.

Patterns rotate; treat this as a baseline, not an exhaustive list. When in doubt, walk away.

C. Appendix: Visa Deep-Dive

The full operational read on Amsterdam's long-stay pathways -- primary visa route, secondary fallbacks, and the non-obvious pitfalls that derail applicants. Cross-reference with your citizenship and tax residency before filing.

PRIMARY PATHWAY

DAFT (Dutch-American Friendship Treaty) -- US citizens only

A bilateral treaty dating to 1956 giving US entrepreneurs an easier path to Dutch residency than any other non-EU nationality. Requires setting up a Dutch ZZP (sole proprietorship) or BV (limited company).

Field	Detail
Eligibility	US citizenship + EUR 4,500 invested into a Dutch business bank account + business plan. No minimum income.
Processing Time	6-10 weeks at IND (Immigration + Naturalisation Service). Fast-track appointments available in Amsterdam and Rotterdam.
Cost	IND fees EUR 1,540 (2026). KvK (Chamber of Commerce) registration EUR 80. Accountant setup EUR 500-1,500. Total first-year: EUR 2,000-4,000.
Stay Duration	2 years initially, renewable for 5 years, then path to permanent residence after 5 years of legal stay.
Perks & Benefits	Full access to Dutch healthcare, banking, BSN, DigiD. Dependents can apply. Dutch citizenship after 5 years if fluent in Dutch (A2/B1).

Secondary Pathways

Route	Summary
Highly Skilled Migrant (Kennismigrant)	Employer-sponsored; salary thresholds 2026: EUR 5,688/month (30+), EUR 4,171/month (under 30), EUR 2,989/month (post-grad route). 30% ruling often available.
Orientation Year (Zoekjaar)	1-year job-search post-Dutch-masters; converts easily to Highly Skilled Migrant once hired. Only works if you graduated from a Dutch or top-100 global university.
Startup Visa	1-year entrepreneur visa, requires accreditation from a recognised Dutch facilitator (Rockstart, YES!Delft) + self-funding.

Non-Obvious Pitfalls

- DAFT is US-only; no other nationality qualifies. Dual-nationals with US passport can use it.
- BSN appointments in Amsterdam are backlogged 4-8 weeks 2026. Some new arrivals register in satellite cities (Almere, Haarlem) first to jump the queue.
- Dutch taxes are steep: income tax up to 49.5% on >EUR 75k; plan the 30% ruling (EUR 0 tax on first 30% of salary for skilled migrants) as employee.
- The 30% ruling is being phased down 2024-2027: from 30% → 20% → 10% over 5 years. DAFT self-employed do NOT qualify for 30% ruling.

Immigration rules change; verify current fees and thresholds on the official government portal before filing. This guide reflects 2026 Q1 status.